hands of colonial justice, a handcuffed Bhagat Singh, still on hunger strike, had to be brought to court on a stretcher. His weight had fallen by 14 lbs from 133 to 119 lbs. His trial had originally started off in Borstal Jail in Lahore on 10 July 1929. Kiron Das, the younger brother of Jatin Das recalls how, as the trial opened at 7 a.m., 'all approaches to the jail as far as Lawrence Gardens were strictly guarded by the police'.[8] After all, he and his younger colleagues were charged with murder, conspiracy and waging war against the King.

From there the case was transferred to the stately Poonch House, where it commenced on 5 May 1930. The composition of the judicial bench originally consisted of Justice Coldstream (President), Justice G.C. Hilton and Justice Agha Haider. So inept, back-handed and injudicious was the conduct of the proceedings, however, that just two weeks later two of the judges were removed by Chief Justice Shadhi Lal of the Lahore High Court: Justice Coldstream for presiding over the physical mistreatment of the accused and Justice Agha Haider for refusing to support such abuse.

The composition of the tribunal then changed on 20 June 1930 to comprise Justice G.C. Hilton (President), Justice Tapp and Justice Sir Abdul Qadir, the latter being a more compliant judge. None of this would have inspired confidence in proceedings that led to Bhagat Singh's eventual death at the hands of the state. Such was the conspicuous vulgarity of his abuse that it extended into the courtroom. Bhagat Singh and his fellow prisoners were mercilessly beaten in front of the magistrate. The violence of colonialism is well known in its physical beatings, imprisonment and routine hangings. What is not so well known is how such violence also entered the courtroom in circumstances where the essence of the courtroom proceedings was to provide a veneer of legality to what was otherwise nothing short of state oppression, and yet here was a case where the mask not just slipped but fell right down, to expose the reality of colonial coercion even in a court of law. It deserves therefore to be recognized as coercive colonial legalism pure and simple. Yet, the violence of the courtroom, both real and symbolic, has thus far escaped the attention it deserves.